STIVEN CATALYST

FIRST SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

FROM THE BEST ON THE TEAM TO THE MANAGER

Why the best people at the job do not become the best managers by themselves, what changes when you cross the line, and how to make the step less risky.

31% of supervisors promoted for their results or tenure as frontline workers are engaged, against 42% of those chosen for supervisory skill.

GALLUP, 2026

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Most frontline supervisors were promoted for their results or tenure as workers. The subject here is the day when the person who did the work better than anyone has to get it done through others.

Laurence Peter named the problem in 1969. Five decades later, three economists measured it in sales: the best salespeople were promoted more often and led teams that sold less. In 2026 Gallup found a similar pattern among frontline supervisors. The step can be learned, but only once it is clear what changes: the skills, the time and what you value.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

The best salesperson, the weakest manager?

In 1969 Laurence Peter and Raymond Hull wrote, with irony, that in a hierarchy every employee tends to rise to their level of incompetence. A 2019 study by three economists tested the idea with sales data.

Alan Benson, Danielle Li and Kelly Shue analysed data on salespeople at many US companies. The companies promoted their top sellers more often. But after the promotion, their teams sold less: when someone's sales before the promotion were twice as high, each team member's sales under them fell by about 6.1%. The study shows a link, not proof that the promotion caused the drop.

1969
The Peter Principle: rising to the level of incompetence.

2001
The Leadership Pipeline: six passages, the first from self to others.

2019
Quarterly Journal of Economics: the top sellers' teams sell less.

2026
Gallup: supervisors chosen for skill are more engaged.

OUR READING

A promotion rewards what someone has done on their own. Management asks what they will achieve through others. Yet one figure, their own past results, often decides both.

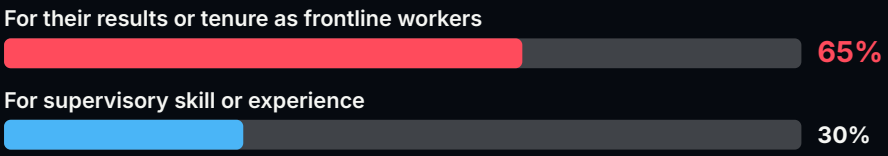
Sources: Laurence J. Peter & Raymond Hull, 1969; Ram Charan, Stephen Drotter & James Noel, 2001; Alan Benson, Danielle Li & Kelly Shue, Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2019; Corey Tatel & Andy Stewart, Gallup, 2026

THE NUMBERS

How supervisors are chosen

Gallup asked frontline supervisors why they were promoted. The answer is linked to how engaged they are today.

WHY THEY WERE PROMOTED, BY THEIR OWN ACCOUNT



Share of frontline supervisors in Gallup's 2026 study, as they themselves explain their promotion.

ENGAGED SUPERVISORS, BY REASON FOR PROMOTION



Share engaged within each group of frontline supervisors, Gallup 2026. A link, not proof that the reason for promotion causes it.

Gallup advises choosing supervisors for supervisory talent rather than mainly for frontline results or seniority, with evidence-based interviews and assessments.

OUR READING

The reason someone was promoted outlasts the day of the promotion: Gallup finds it again in the supervisor's engagement.

Source: Corey Tatel & Andy Stewart, Gallup, 2026

THE MODEL

Three things that change

In The Leadership Pipeline, Charan, Drotter and Noel describe the first passage, from managing yourself to managing others, as a change in three things at once.

Skills	Time	Values
01 Planning other people's work	01 Time set aside for people	01 Results come through others
02 Choosing people and delegating	02 Time to plan, not only to do	02 The team's success as one's own
03 Coaching and assessing the work	03 Fewer hours on one's own tasks	03 Managing as real work

The authors write that the values are harder to change than the skills: believing that a manager's work is real work, and no obstacle to the “real work”.

OUR READING

Most new managers know they should delegate. Few change their calendar. The step shows in the week before it shows in the results.

Source: Ram Charan, Stephen Drotter & James Noel, 2001

The three categories are the book's; the examples within them are our summary.

More in the essay The Operations Manager I want to be

DEVELOPING THE ROLE

Five expectations that do not hold

Linda Hill has studied new managers for years. In 2007 she summed up their expectations in five myths, each with the reality that replaces it. The right-hand column is our summary.

01	**The manager has authority**	The manager depends on others: the boss, peers, the team and people outside it.
02	**Power comes from the title**	Power comes from trust, earned through character and competence.
03	**Control is the goal**	Compliance is not commitment; commitment is the goal.
04	**Managing one by one**	Beyond each person, the team as a whole has to be led.
05	**Keeping things running smoothly**	The job is also to change how the team works.

Most supervisors meet these myths without preparation. In Gallup's 2026 study, fewer than half had any supervisor training in the past year, and those who had were more likely to be engaged and less likely to burn out often.

45%
had supervisor training in the past year

23%
have never had any

79%
more likely to be engaged if they had training in the past year

OUR READING

What a new manager needs most is agreements: with the team, with the boss and with peers. Authority comes with the title; these have to be made.

Sources: Linda A. Hill, Harvard Business Review, 2007; Corey Tatel & Andy Stewart, Gallup, 2026

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Where does your week go?

The step shows in the calendar before it shows in the results. One honestly recorded week tells you whether you are still the best worker or have started to be a manager.

1. **Record one week**
   Every hour, what you did. Without dressing it up.
2. **Split it into three**
   Your own work, work with the team (planning, coaching, conversations), and fires.
3. **Decide how many hours the team gets**
   Together with your boss. One number for next month.
4. **Hand over one task**
   Each week, one thing you still do yourself goes to someone on the team, with time to learn it.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD IN THE FIRST MONTH

Own work	22 hours
With the team	8 hours
Fires	10 hours

The goal for next month: 15 hours with the team. All figures invented.

OUR READING

When fires take more hours than the team, the usual cause is that nobody else knows how to put them out.

The steps and the example are the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The transition card

One page for your first three months as a manager. Fill it in yourself, then discuss it with your boss.

01 What I stop doing myself the tasks that go to the team

02 Time for the team when, how many hours, for what

03 One-to-one conversations with whom, how often

04 The skill I am learning one this month

05 Who I depend on boss, peers, other units

06 Review date, and where the week went

The editors suggest this as a practice. Leave names and confidential data off the card.

More in the essay “Watch how I do it” is not training

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

The Peter Principle
Laurence J. Peter & Raymond Hull, 1969

Promotions and the Peter Principle
Alan Benson, Danielle Li & Kelly Shue, Quarterly Journal of Economics, 2019
https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qjz022

When Good Frontline Workers Make Bad Supervisors
Corey Tatel & Andy Stewart, Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/700163/when-good-frontline-workers-make-bad-supervisors.aspx

The Leadership Pipeline
Ram Charan, Stephen Drotter & James Noel, 2001

Becoming the Boss
Linda A. Hill, Harvard Business Review, 2007
https://hbr.org/2007/01/becoming-the-boss

CORRECTION · 13 OCTOBER 2026

The study by three economists that tested the Peter Principle with sales data (Benson, Li and Shue) is from 2019, as the sources give it; the text first said 2018.

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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